

Thumbnail Playbook

Click-Optimized Concepts & Generation Prompts

Video: "What Happens to the Human Brain During Total Darkness" — The Ancient Brain

Part 1 — Full Concepts with Generation Prompts

1 **The Reaching Hand in the Dark** (fear + mystery)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, full pure black background, @shady on the right side as a glowing white outline with wide terrified circular eyes and an open frightened mouth, both stick arms reaching desperately into the empty black, the figure small against an overwhelming void, a single faint white spark of light far away that he can't reach, dramatic high contrast, flat colors, bold thick outlines, no other elements.

TEXT OVERLAY (LEFT, HUGE BOLD YELLOW)

3 DAYS. NO LIGHT.

2 **Brain Hijack** (science + shock)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, split frame, left half white with @shady's round head in profile and a lumpy yellow brain inside glowing normally, right half deep navy-black with the same head but the brain now firing red lightning bolts and projecting ghostly hallucination shapes (a face, an eye) out of the skull, shocked expression, bold thick black outlines, flat high-contrast colors.

TEXT OVERLAY (TOP, BOLD WHITE WITH BLACK STROKE)

YOUR BRAIN STARTS LYING

3 **34 vs 63** (number gap = curiosity)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, white-to-navy gradient background, @shady center with both hands on the sides of his head in total shock, mouth a wide open O, on the left a giant black "34" and on the right a giant red "63" with a red arrow between them, bold thick outlines, flat colors, dramatic and clean.

TEXT OVERLAY (BOTTOM, BOLD RED)

HE LOST 29 DAYS

4 **The Eye That Sees Nothing** (eerie close-up)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, pure black background, one enormous white-outlined human eye filling the frame, the pupil replaced by a hypnotic spiral, faint glowing hallucination shapes swirling inside the iris, extreme close-up, high contrast, bold thick outlines, unsettling, flat colors.

TEXT OVERLAY (BOTTOM-LEFT, BOLD YELLOW)

WHAT THE DARK SHOWS YOU

5 **Sealed Inside** (story hook)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, white background fading to black at the bottom, @shady in a hard hat descending on a rope into a black cave oval, only his upper body still in the light, looking up with a worried face, a heavy stone slab half-covering the cave mouth above him, bold thick outlines, flat dramatic colors.

TEXT OVERLAY (TOP, BOLD WHITE)

SEALED IN THE DARK FOR 6 MONTHS

6 **Open Eyes, Empty Bed** (relatable dread)

PROMPT

MS Paint / hand-drawn 2D doodle style, navy-black bedroom, @shady lying flat in bed with two wide white staring eyes glowing in the dark, everything else swallowed by black, a faint creeping shadow at the edges, high contrast, bold outlines, flat colors.

TEXT OVERLAY (TOP, BOLD YELLOW)

WHY YOU CAN'T SLEEP IN THE DARK

Part 2 — Concepts Paired with Titles

CTR comes from thumbnail + title working *together* — the thumbnail shows the emotion/number, the title delivers the context.

1 **The Countdown Horror** (curiosity gap + number)

Black thumbnail, @shady's terrified glowing-white face on one side, a giant cracked “72” with a small red “HOURS” beneath. The number does the hooking.

Title: “What Happens to Your Brain After 72 Hours of Total Darkness”

2 **The Two-Faces Split** (transformation)

Left half: @shady calm in white light. Right half: same face warped, wide-eyed, hallucinating, drowning in black. A jagged line splits them.

Title: “Total Darkness Doesn't Just Scare You — It Rewires You”

3 **The Self-Insert Dread** (the “YOU” hook)

@shady lying in bed, only two huge white eyes glowing in pitch black, shadow creeping in. The viewer pictures themselves — highest-retention hook for a science video.

Title: “Why Your Brain Panics in the Dark (It's Not Anxiety)”

4 **The Brain Betrayal** (shock + science authority)

A stickman skull cross-section, the brain glowing then firing red lightning and projecting a ghost face out of the head.

Title: “Your Brain Invents a Reality in the Dark”

5 **The Lost-Time Reveal** (strongest number gap)

@shady clutching his head in shock between a black “34” and a red “63”.

Title: “He Thought It Was 34 Days. It Was 63.”

6 **The Spiral Eye** (eerie, scroll-stopping)

One enormous eye filling the frame, pupil replaced by a hypnotic spiral, faint hallucinations swirling inside the iris.

Title: "What the Dark Makes You See"

Part 3 — The Strategy (Why These Win the Algorithm)

- **Dark = your unfair advantage.** Your topic lets you go nearly all-black. In a feed of bright thumbnails, a black one stands out — an instant visibility edge.
- **One emotion, one face, big eyes.** Fear/shock on a face reads at phone size in under a second. That's where CTR is won.
- **A number or an unfinished thought.** “72,” “34 vs 63,” “It's not anxiety” — each opens a gap the brain wants closed.
- **3 words of text, max.** Yellow or red, fat font, thick black outline. If it isn't readable on a phone, it doesn't exist.
- **Brand the @shady face every time.** Repeat viewers recognize your style, which compounds CTR over months — the algorithm rewards rising returning-viewer click rates.
- **Title and thumbnail must NOT say the same thing.** Thumbnail = emotion/number; title = context. Together they create tension. Highest-converting structure.

Recommendation: Launch with **#5 (34 vs 63)** or **#1 (72 Hours)** first — number-gap thumbnails are the most reliable performers for explainer content. Then A/B test against **#3 (the bed / glowing eyes)** to see whether the “you” angle beats the “story” angle with your audience.